HCP 1205 (cpc_--_HU__HU_Rakos Palota Ujfalu_jolanka-60): Jolánka to Feri Holecz, the two-hundredth card

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

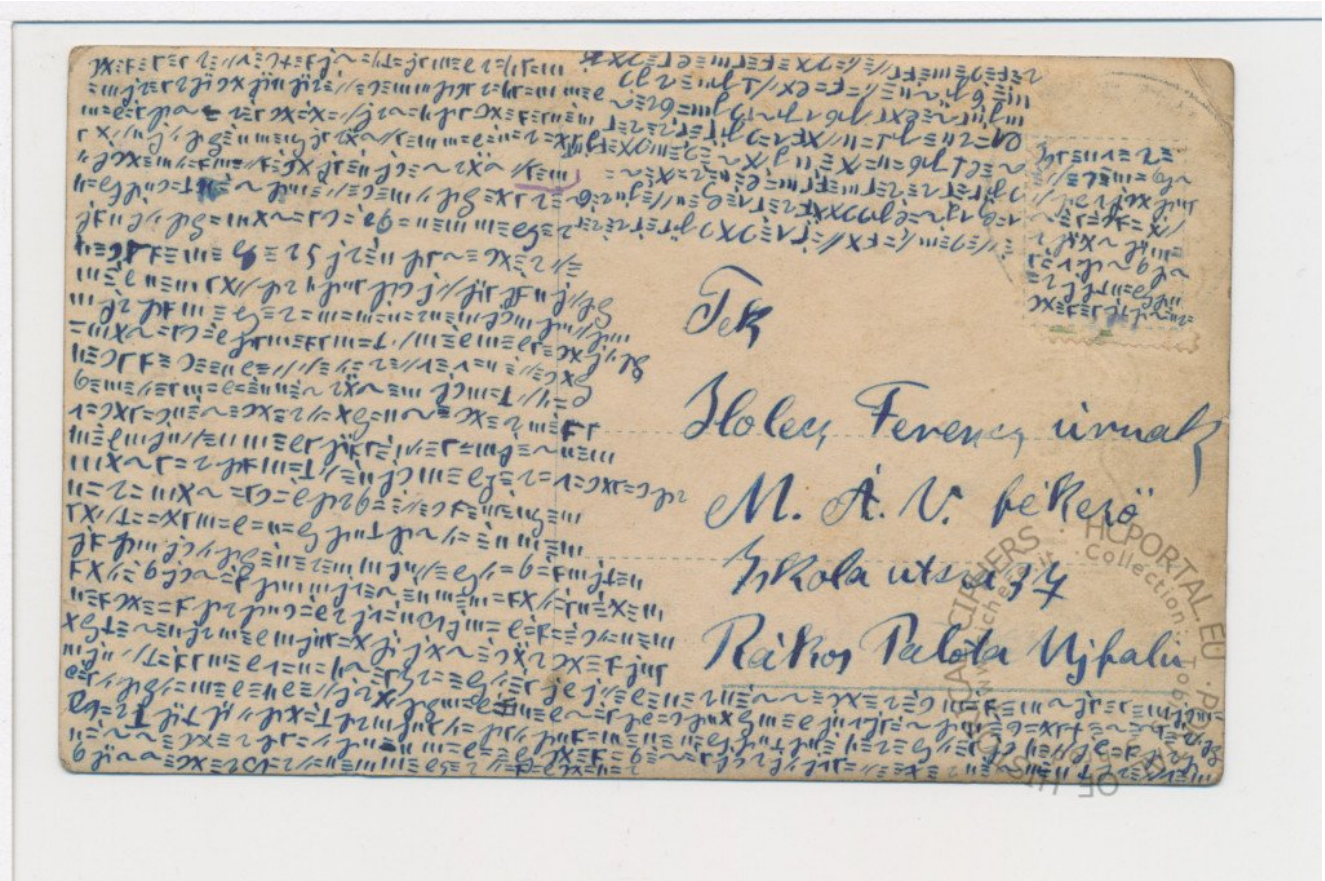
Status: read in full (1239 written signs); review 1 verdict REVISE, review 2 verdict REVISE, all findings addressed. No clause stays unread; the doubtful points are single signs, listed below. Report dated 2026-11-02.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1205 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1205), portal name cpc_--_HU__HU_Rakos Palota Ujfalu_jolanka-60, part of Tobias Schrödel's collection of cryptographic postcards (private collection). When it was captured on 2026-11-02 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, tagged Postcard and T. Schrödel Collection, category Substitution, language Unknown, sender Unknown, recipient Holecz Ferenc, with no transcription or solution attached. The portal links a HistoCrypt article, which was not read for this work, so we cannot say whether it prints this card.

The address side is in clear: **Tek. Holecz Ferencz úrnak, M.Á.V. fékező, Iskola utcza 34, Rákos Palota Ujfalu** ("To the Honourable Ferencz Holecz, brakeman of the Hungarian State Railways, Iskola utca 34, Rákospalota-Újfalu"). Cipher text fills the rest of that side: the left half and the bottom, an upper right block written with the card turned 180 degrees, and a small block under the stamp. The picture side carries a printed verse in clear. The postmark gives no usable date.

The card belongs to the "Jolánka" family of Hungarian cipher postcards. Most of them are addressed to Tóth Jolánka; this one goes the other way. The writer signs Jolánka in cipher, and the recipient is the Feri of HCP 1267, who writes there that he has become a brakeman at Rákospalota. Her language is plain and loving: the card counts their correspondence, cancels a dance, plans a stay with relatives and advises him on what cloth to buy.



Address side, with all the cipher text (source/address-large.jpg)



Picture side with the printed verse (source/picture-large.jpg)

Method

The key was known before reading began: it is the family key of the finished cards HCP 1216 and 1267. This is a key transfer, not a blind recovery, and no new letter value was needed. No earlier work existed on this number, and no published solution of this card was found or used.

The transcription is manual. Claude Opus 5.5 read the signs by eye from enlarged crops of the un-converted original scan, in 43 written rows, and recorded one character per sign in a ledger, with no OCR. Rows 01-27 stand upright, rows U1-U8 are upside down, and rows S1-S8 lie under the stamp. At the divider the upright and upside-down rows butt together, so the crops had to be split there. The order of the three blocks in the reading is editorial: greeting first, signature last.

Key

Cipher type: **MASC + Steganography** (updated 2026-11-03). The stamp is lifted, and under it the writer hid eight rows in the cipher signs (rows S1-S8: the closing greeting and signature), so the card also carries a message concealed under the stamp.

Hungarian, simple monoalphabetic substitution with invented graphic signs. The labels are descriptions of handwritten shapes. Accent and dot marks stand over the base sign and are used loosely.

sign	letter	sign	letter	sign	letter
two bars	a	section mark / S	k	F-like	r
six	b	wave or small arch	l	right bowl	s
opposed bowls, also loop + v-stroke	cs	three short strokes	m	gamma/corner	t
double slash	d	two short strokes	n	plain cross x	u
three bars	e	loop + hook, descending	o, or with a dot pair ö	chevron	v
upright cross +	f	tall stroke + short tick	h, p	crossed curve, dotted	i
open loop	g	inverted T	j	crossed diagonal with tail	z
zigzag	y (pletyka, and in ny)	loop joined to descender	gy		

The tall + short sign stands for h and p, and the word decides which. One token, the first sign of nagyon in row 06, has the same form and is read n by sense alone. The double slash stands for h five times, also by sense. Three short strokes make m, and the first stroke can stand free of a joined pair (rows 05, 25). A written digit 5 stands in row 08, as clear figures do on HCP 1267.

So 43 signs (h 30, p 7, n 1, double slash 5) are told apart by word sense, not by shape alone. This is the main limit of the reading, and it is shared by the family.

Plaintext

Literal decipherment, row by row, as printed by the reproduction command. ? flags a doubtful sign and {struck} a sign the writer struck out. The accents are mostly not written.

```
01 szeretetkedvesferilapjaitmegkaptam
02 amiketköszönökedesemmostkaptammeg
03 magatole?ketszazadiklapotszeretnem
04 tudnihogyenmenyitküldtemmaganakaz
05 hiszemharmedreszitenisélküldtem
```

```
06 nagyonsajn?alomedesemhogyeztkel
07 irnihogyamulatsagbanemmegyek
08 pestremegyek5ikenotleszekde
09 megnemtudokpontosidötirnihogy
10 mikormegyekamamanaknemismondom
11 amulatsagotmertmajdmegmegteszihogy
12 pestreseengednehakedvevanedesugy
13 bemehetmagaennelkülemismajdha
14 vasutasneleszekhauganleszekmert
15 megmindenmegtörtenhetamielnem
16 multakormajdenismegyekavasutasok
17 nakamulatsagokbaedesrem?enyem
18 tudjaaztmaganagyonjolhaennem
19 iromishogyenekemmindeghabarmij?en
20 ruhabolat?ommivelennemaruhatnezem
21 perszearokonsagkivancsimagaraeshanem
22 ugyjelenikmegmintazizlesükszerint
23 mindjartmegvanapletykaegyhetigidegeneknelleszekesmaremlitetemisma
24 gathogyhamegengedikh?ogymaga{struck}megletigasonugymeginvitelomesaztfeleltehogy
25 csakjöjöhozejokminthaothonramenena?gyonjonepekegyhetispedigaroko
26 nalleszekotahone?nmagaegiszerabelatiskihivitadeezeknelnemjokeedvem
27 bölleszekcsakhanemmegyekharagszanak
U1 edesemharuhatveszsötetkeket
U2 vagvilagosszürketvegyendeinkab
U3 sötetkeketmertmaganakaza?la
U4 legjobanazenizlesemszerint
U5 csakneojandurvasötetkeket
U6 mintlegutobvoltsimabkel
U7 mebölneharagudjonekis
U8 keresemertdehaszeretmegteszi
S1 istenvele
S2 edesemabol
S3 dogviszont
S4 letesra?üd
S5 vözlöma
S6 tavolbol
S7 akiojnagyon
S8 szeretijolanka
```



Row 25, the sign that decided the word group: j-o, n-e, then long stroke + tick (p) and e, read jó népek (review/work/crops2/g2.png)

Normalized Hungarian (word division, accents and spelling are editorial):

Szeretet[t] kedves Feri! Lapjait megkaptam, amiket köszönök, édesem. Most kaptam meg magától e kétszázadik lapot. Szeretném tudni, hogy én mennyit küldtem magának, azt hiszem, harmadrészét én is elküldtem. Nagyon sajnálom, édesem, hogy ezt kell írni, hogy a mulatságba nem megyek. Pestre megyek 5-ikén, ott leszek, de még nem tudok pontos időt írni, hogy mikor megyek. A mamának nem is mondom a mulatságot, mert majd még megteszi, hogy Pestre se engedne. Ha kedve van, édes, úgy bemehet maga én nélkülem is. Majd ha vasutasné leszek, ha ugyan leszek, mert még minden megtörténhet, ami el nem múlt, akkor majd én is megyek a vasutasoknak a mulatságokba, édes reményem. Tudja azt maga nagyon jól, ha én nem írom is, hogy énnekem mindegy, habár milyen ruhából látom, mivel én nem a ruhát nézem. Persze a rokonság kíváncsi magára, és ha nem úgy jelenik meg, mint az ízlésük szerint, mindjárt megvan a pletyka. Egy hétig idegeneknél leszek, és már említettem is magát, hogy ha megengedik, hogy maga meglátogasson,

úgy meginvitálom, és azt felelte, hogy csak jöjjön hozzájok, mintha otthonra menne. Nagyon jó népek. Egy hét is pedig a rokonnál leszek ott, ahonnan maga egyszer a Bélát is kihívta, de ezeknél nem jó kedvemből leszek, csak ha nem megyek, haragszanak.

Upside-down block: Édesem, ha ruhát vesz, sötétkéket vagy világosszürkét vegyen, de inkább sötétkéket, mert magának az áll a legjobban az én ízlésem szerint. Csak ne olyan durva sötétkéket, mint legutóbb volt, simább kelméből. Ne haragudjon e kis kérésemért, de ha szeret, megteszi.

Under the stamp: Isten vele, édesem, a boldog viszontlátásra. Üdvözlöm a távolból, aki oly nagyon szereti, Jolánka.

Address in clear: Tek. Holecz Ferencz úrnak, M.Á.V. fékező, Iskola utcza 34, Rákos Palota Ujfalu.

Printed on the picture side, in clear: Két sziv ha földobog. / Két sziv ha földobog, álmodón, / Két sziv ha földobog, lángolón, / Felhők közé ne szállj .... / Dörén csalódni fáj.

English

Beloved dear Feri! I have received your cards, for which I thank you, my sweet. I have just got this two-hundredth card from you. I would like to know how many I have sent you; I think I have sent a third of that too. I am very sorry, my sweet, to have to write that I am not going to the dance. I am going to Pest on the 5th and will be there, but I cannot yet write the exact time when I go. I am not even telling Mama about the dance, because she might even see to it that I would not be allowed to Pest either. If you feel like it, dear, you may go in without me. When I become a railwayman's wife, if I ever do, for anything can still happen that has not yet passed, then I too will go to the railwaymen's dances, my sweet hope. You know very well, even if I do not write it, that it is all the same to me in whatever clothes I see you, since I do not look at the clothes. Of course the relatives are curious about you, and if you do not appear as is to their taste, straight away there is gossip. I will be with strangers for a week, and I have already mentioned you, that if they permit you to visit me, I will invite you, and she answered that you should just come to them as if you were going home. Very good people. And for a week too I shall be at the relative's, there from where you once called Béla out too, but with these I shall not stay gladly; it is only that if I do not go, they will be angry.

Upside-down block: My sweet, if you buy clothes, take dark blue or light grey, but rather dark blue, because that suits you best in my taste. Only not such a coarse dark blue as last time; of smoother cloth. Do not be angry at this small request of mine, but if you love me, you will do it.

Under the stamp: God be with you, my sweet, until a happy reunion. I greet you from afar, she who loves you so much, Jolánka.

Address in clear: To the Honourable Ferencz Holecz, M.Á.V. [Hungarian State Railways] brakeman, Iskola utca 34, Rákospalota-Újfalu.

Printed verse: Two hearts, if they leap up. / Two hearts, if they leap up, dreaming, / two hearts, if they leap up, in flame, / do not soar among the clouds .... / to be foolishly disappointed hurts.

Slovak

Milovaný drahý Feri! Vaše lístky som dostala, za ktoré ďakujem, môj drahý. Práve som od Vás dostala tento dvojstý lístok. Rada by som vedela, koľko som ich poslala ja Vám; myslím, že aj ja som poslala tretinu z toho. Veľmi ma mrzí, drahý, že musím napísať, že na zábavu nepôjdem. Pôjdem do Pešti piateho a budem tam, ale ešte nemôžem napísať presný čas, kedy pôjdem. Mame o zábave ani nehovorím, lebo by ešte spravila to, že by ma ani do Pešti nepustila. Ak máte chuť, drahý, môžete ísť dnu aj bezo mňa. Keď budem manželkou železničiara, ak vôbec budem, lebo sa ešte všetko môže stať, čo nepominulo, potom aj ja budem chodiť na zábavy železničiarov, moja sladká nádej. Veď to dobre viete, aj keď to nepíšem, že mne je jedno, v akom oblečení Vás vidím, keďže ja nepozerám na oblečenie. Pravdaže, príbuzní sú na Vás zvedaví, a ak sa neukážete tak, ako je podľa ich vkusu, hneď sú z toho klebety. Týždeň budem u cudzích ľudí a už som Vás spomenula, že ak dovolia, aby ste ma navštívili, tak Vás pozvem, a odpovedala, že nech len príde k nim, akoby šiel domov. Veľmi dobrí ľudia. A aj týždeň budem u príbuzného, tam, odkiaľ ste raz vyvolali aj Bélu, ale u týchto nebudem z dobrej vôle; len keď nepôjdem, budú sa hnevať.

Prevrátený blok: Môj drahý, ak si budete kupovať oblečenie, vezmite si tmavomodré alebo svetlosivé, ale radšej tmavomodré, lebo to Vám podľa môjho vkusu pristane najviac. Len nie také hrubé tmavomodré ako naposledy, z hladšej látky. Nehnevajte sa pre túto moju malú prosbu, ale ak ma ľúbite, urobíte to.

Pod známkou: S Bohom, môj drahý, do šťastného videnia. Pozdravujem Vás zďaleka, tá, ktorá Vás tak veľmi ľúbi, Jolánka.

Adresa v otvorenom texte: Váženému pánovi Ferenczovi Holeczovi, brzdár M.Á.V. [Maďarské štátne železnice], Iskola utca 34, Rákospalota-Újfalu.

Tlačený verš: Dve srdcia, keď zabúšia. / Dve srdcia, keď zabúšia, snívajúc, / dve srdcia, keď zabúšia, v plameni, / nevzlietni medzi oblaky .... / sklamať sa pochabo bolí.

Uncertainties

1. **Row 25** `jonepek` is read jó népek "good people". The o carries no visible dots, which gives jó, and the sign after e is the ordinary p, in the same form as pedig in that row. Sign form and word sense support each other. Népek has its é unmarked, as usual on this card.
2. **Row 26** `otahone?n` is read ot[t] ahon[n]an = ott, ahonnan, "there, from where". This call rests on sense, because the vowel lies under a blot: one thin bar over a thick blob. The sign is either a (two bars, plain ahonan) or e (three bars, a dialect ahonnen); the word is the same, so the literal row keeps e? as a flagged sign. No sentence comes of ott a hon én. Maga is then "you", as everywhere on this card. Kihívta "called out" could mean summoned out or challenged; the Béla story is not known.
3. **Row 25** `na?gyon`: the sign after n is two bars with a tick below, which may belong to another row. The word decides a. **Row 20** `lat?om`: taken as t, not r (one clear bar, crossed by a gy tail above); the six strokes are m + m of látom, mivel. Sense decides.
4. **Row 08** `5`: shape, with a flat top flag, plus sense; a y is not wholly excluded.
5. **Row 24** `h?ogy`: a flagged x stands for the h of hogy as one composite sign. A sign after maga is cross-hatched by the writer and not read. The next sign shows two strokes, read m of meg. A third stroke may lie under the hatching, or the writer may have corrected a false start; meglátogasson is not in doubt. **Row 25** `jöjö hozejok`: one sign (long + short slash) only, so the n of jöjjön is taken as dropped.
6. **Zigzag** `Y`: after review 1 the plain y value rests on pletyka alone; it also occurs in ny (rows 04, 17).
7. **Row 17** `rem?enyem`: the third stroke of m has a small flag. Sense fixes reményem, which also occurs on HCP1216.
8. **Row 19** `mij?en`: a sign like a tilted cross read as j (dialect mijen = milyen, parallel to ojan). Reading it as f gives no word.

9. **Row 06**: the n of sajnálom lies under a blot; **row 03**: the e after magától is partly under a blot. **U3** `a?la`: the a of áll could be e. Sense-fixed.
10. Writer's spellings normalized: harmed → harmad, kel → kell, ot → ott, ugan → ugyan, letigason → látogasson, invitelom → invitálom, kihivita → kihívta, keedvem → kedvem, oj → oly, inkab → inkább, simab → simább, mene → menne, jöjö → jöjjön, hozejok → hozzájok, menyit → mennyit, othonra → otthonra, rokonál → rokonnál, vag → vagy. Accents are often invisible and are supplied. S1 begins with a faint i s, read by sense over the stamp ghost.
11. A purple pencil curve near the divider is not cipher. The date is not legible and is not claimed (the 5th has no month). The order of the three blocks is editorial. In the printed verse, Dörén is transcribed as it looks; I read it as dőrén "foolishly", taking the accent of the small type as two short strokes, and this is a reading by sense.

The accents, the word division and the punctuation of the normalized text are editorial. Who Béla was is unknown, and so is the month of "the 5th".

Why the reading is trusted

The family key gives Hungarian across all the signs, in three separate blocks and two orientations. Long stretches come out with no guidance from context: kétszázadik lapot, vasutasné leszek, sötétkéket vagy világosszürkét vegyen, simább kelméből, ne haragudjon e kis kérésemért, de ha szeret, megteszi. The content fits HCP 1267: a railwayman's wife and the railwaymen's dances are exactly right for a M.Á.V. brakeman, and the signature and clear address confirm both parties.

Reproduction

From the repository root:

```
python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1205/work/decode.py
```

The script checks the SHA-256 of both scans and both originals, decodes the sign ledger work/ledger.txt, and prints the 43 literal rows and the normalized text. It does not read the image: the transcription step is manual and was checked in review against crops.

Review summary

An independent Claude Opus 5.5 agent reviewed two rounds, each with verdict **REVISE**. It ran the command, wrote its own decoder (same 43 rows) and checked the ledger against its own crops.

Round 1 raised thirteen findings, all accepted. They corrected signs and word divisions (for example Persze, simább kelméből, 5-ikén, Hiszem) and removed a false reading at the end of the card. Following up on one finding, the solver reread rows 25-26, found nagyon, menne and ott, ahonnan, and sent the card back for a second check. In that pass it also corrected the reviewer on the m of menne.

Round 2 raised six findings, all accepted:

- **Row 25.** The open word group is jó népek, because the sign is the ordinary p; it had been forced to n.
- **Sentence.** Egy hét is pedig a rokonnál leszek is a complete sentence, and the English and Slovak were rewritten.
- **Value n.** The class "tall + short also n" was overstated. Rows 04 and 14 are plain n, and one token remains (row 06).
- **Wording.** The status line and the note on ott, ahonnan were corrected.
- **Row 26 blot.** Disclosed as a or e, with the word unchanged.
- **Row 24 strike.** A third stroke under the hatching is disclosed.

After review 2 the solver also explained the printed word Dörén as dőrén, "foolishly". That change touches no cipher sign and has not been reviewed. The reviewer read every row in round 1; in round 2 it rechecked rows 23-27 and sampled the others, U1-U8 included.

Transcription, key transfer, decipherment and this report are by Claude Opus 5.5; the review is by a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent.

Sources

- HC Portal record 1205, General, Description and Attachments tabs, captured 2026-11-02: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1205 (source/metadata.md).
- Scans: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3675/ (picture side) and https://api.hcportal.eu/media/3676/ (address side); originals in work/hires/.
- Family key: ciphers/hcp-1216 and ciphers/hcp-1267 in this repository.
- AI Decipherment Register (https://ai.hcportal.eu/register/), checked by the orchestrator on 2026-11-02: no record for this card.